



KARA Marsh of Altadena gets emotional as she looks for items in the ruins of her home after the Eaton fire.

Bidding *adiós* to Castro, Guevara

Removing Mexico City monument renews a political battle

By Patrick J. McDonnell

MEXICO CITY — Good-bye, Fidel. *Hasta la vista, Che.* Denunciations and accolades greeted the abrupt removal this month of a controversial monument in the Mexican capital commemorating the two revolutionaries, Fidel Castro and Ernesto “Che” Guevara.

The monument, a pair of bronze, life-size sculptures of Castro and Guevara chilling on a bench, recalls a consequential moment in both Mexican and Cuban history: the pair’s first meeting, which took place in an apartment in Mexico City in June or July 1955, according to historians. At the time, both were twentysomething militants in the formative stages of their transformation into

leftist icons who would inspire a global generation of revolutionaries and activists. A leftist Mexico City government installed the monument in 2017 in a small park in the Colonia Tabacalera neighborhood, not far from where the storied duo first met in a Cold War encounter that has taken on near-mythical dimensions among many on the left. In the two sculptures,

both men stare straight ahead and are decked out in light combat garb — Guevara in his trademark beret (a look immortalized on T-shirts across the globe) and Castro sporting a fighter’s cap. His legs crossed, Castro grasps a cigar in his left hand, and a book in his right. Guevara’s right hand secures a pipe. The sculpture has long sparked polemics: Although

Federal cuts and raids threaten programs for migrant students

At LAUSD, fewer of them participate this summer

By Howard Blume



LAUSD migrant education program students share axolotl artwork at L.A. Zoo.

The 8-year-old girl is a migrant student whose family moves frequently in search of seasonal work. But for five weeks this summer, she found stability, fun and academic nurturing in a program for children like her that included visits to the L.A. Zoo twice a week. But like the axolotl, the salamander she studied, this program is critically endangered. Because migrant students may have family members who are living in the country illegally — or may themselves lack legal status — the Trump administration wants to end federal funding for it, saying the program wastes money and violates his policy directives. And in a more immediate blow to the program, amid fears over immigration-enforcement raids, fewer children went to the zoo and virtually no parents attended concurrent education workshops on how to support their children’s learning. Although the federally funded zoo experience is a tiny program in the Los Angeles Unified School District — and a small part of a summer school that reaches tens of thousands of students, it offers a window into how Trump administration poli-

How cloud seeding sparked Texas flood theory

Scientists quickly debunk allegations against SoCal-based company Rainmaker.

By Hayley Smith

Two days before the waters of the Guadalupe River swelled into a deadly and devastating Fourth of July flood in Kerr County, Texas, engineers with a Los Angeles County-based company called Rainmaker took off in

an airplane about 100 miles away and dispersed 70 grams of silver iodide into a cloud. Their goal? To make it rain over Texas — part of a weather modification practice known as cloud seeding, which uses chemical compounds to augment water droplets inside clouds, making the drops large enough and heavy enough to fall to the ground. But in the hours after the flood swept through the greater Kerrville area and killed at least 135 people, in-

cluding three dozen children, conspiracy theories began swirling among a small but vocal group of fringe figures. “I NEED SOMEONE TO LOOK INTO WHO WAS RESPONSIBLE FOR THIS ... WHEN WAS THE LAST CLOUD SEEDING?” wrote Pete Chambers, a former U.S. special forces commander and prominent far-right activist, on the social media platform X. The post received 3.1 million views, yet was only one of several accusations that

sprang up around Rainmaker’s activities and its alleged connection to the flood. “Anyone who calls this out as a conspiracy theory can go F themselves,” wrote Michael Flynn, former national security advisor under the first Trump administration, atop a repost of Chambers’ tweet. The flurry of allegations was quickly debunked, with a number of independent scientists saying that the company’s actions could not have produced anywhere

Claims by Jan. 7 fire victims may go to mediation

More than 1,000 policyholders filed state complaints about issues with insurers.

By Laurence Darmiento

After receiving more than 1,000 complaints from Jan. 7 fire victims about how insurers are handling their claims, state regulators are considering referring hundreds of the cases to mediation — a little used practice that some consumer advocates fear could hurt policyholders. The Department of Insurance has been bombarded with complaints from property owners since the Palisades and Eaton fires destroyed more than 16,000 structures and damaged more than 2,000 others, causing up to \$45 billion in insured damages by one estimate. Fire victims say they have experienced slow responses from insurance company claims handlers, been ro-

tated to multiple adjusters, denied hygienic testing for toxic chemicals and given lowball offers. The department has encouraged fire victims unhappy with how their claims are being managed to file complaints. They are then assigned a compliance officer who attempts to resolve the issues with their insurer. Joy Chen, chief executive and co-founder of the Eaton Fire Survivors Network, which, according to its website, has some 5,000 members, said that the compliance officers have not been successful in sorting out the disputes. “Across thousands of complaints I’ve seen discussed, I have barely heard of a single survivor who said DOI actually helped them resolve their claim,” she said. “At best, people say things like, ‘I finally got a return call from my adjuster — right before they left for vacation again.’” The department says the complaint process has helped policyholders whose homes were destroyed or

Trump team ramps up online trolling

Amid immigration raids, social media posts aim to provoke.

By Hailey Branson-Potts

Morgan Weistling, an accomplished painter of cowboys and Old West frontier life, was vacationing with his family this month when he got a surprising message from a friend about one of his works of art. The U.S. Department of Homeland Security, he said the friend told him, had posted a work he had painted five years ago to its official social media channels without his knowledge. The painting, which looks like a scene from the Oregon Trail, depicts a young white couple — she in a long dress, he in a cowboy hat — cradling a baby in a covered wagon, with mountains and another wagon in

the background. “Remember your Homeland’s Heritage,” the Department of Homeland Security captioned the July 14 post on X, Instagram and Facebook. Exactly whose homeland and whose heritage? And what was the intended message of the federal department, whose masked and heavily armed agents have arrested thousands of brown-skinned, Spanish-speaking immigrants — most with no criminal convictions — in California this summer? That has been the source of heated online debate at a time when the Trump administration has ramped up its online trolling with memes and jokes about the raids that critics have called racist, childish and unbefitting official government social media accounts. The “Remember your Homeland’s Heritage” post racked up 19 million views on

Court volunteers aid detainees before ICE

By Martha Bellisle, Cedar Attanasio and Colleen Slevin

SEATTLE — After a Seattle immigration judge dismissed the deportation case against a Colombian man — exposing him to expedited removal — three people sat with him in the back of the courtroom, taking his car keys for safekeeping, helping him memorize phone numbers and gathering the names of family members who needed to be notified. When Judge Brett Parchert asked why they were doing that in court, the volunteers said Immigration and Custom Enforcement officers were outside the door, waiting to take the man into custody, so this was their only chance to help him get his things in order. “ICE is in the waiting room?” the judge asked. As President Trump’s mass deportation campaign focuses on cities and states led by Democrats and unleashes fear among asylum seekers and immigrants, their legal defenders sued last week, seeking class-action protections against the arrests outside immigration

court hearings. Meanwhile, these volunteers are taking action. A diverse group — faith leaders, college students, grandmothers, retired lawyers and professors — has been showing up at immigration courts across the nation to escort immigrants at risk of being detained for deportation by masked ICE officials. They’re giving families moral and logistical support, and bearing witness as the people are taken away. The Northwest Immigrant Rights Project was inundated by so many community members wanting to help that they made a volunteer training video, created “Know Your Rights” sheets in several languages and started a Google sheet on which people sign up for shifts, said Stephanie Gai, a staff attorney with the Seattle-based legal services nonprofit. “We could not do it without them,” Gai said. “Some volunteers request time off work so they can come in and help.” Robby Rohr, a retired nonprofit director, said she volunteers regularly.

ICE sweeps may hurt bird flu fight
Farmworkers fearing possible arrest by feds may resist testing if an outbreak reoccurs in the fall. **NATION, A5**

Search for L.A. shooting suspect
Police seek answers about the Hollywood nightclub car-ramming attack that prompted gunfire. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Not the end for ‘Late Show’ host
CBS may have canceled Stephen Colbert’s week-night program, but his influence will live on. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather
Turning sunny. L.A. Basin: 79/64. **B6**

